Ghost Stories

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/42703683.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F, Gen

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
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Additional Tags:
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by SuspiciouslyDelightful

Summary

The Princess Alliance knows that, when rebuilding planets and communities, it's important to take the time to kick back, relax, and get Adora to finally tell those damn ghost stories... and hope Entrapta doesn't get up to anything while they're all distracted.

Fright Night

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

They looked around at the bleak metal walls, the piles of debris huddled in sheltered corners, everything highlighted by the harsh flickering lights.

"Well, it could be worse… probably." Glimmer said, wrinkling her nose at one particularly suspect piece of scrap.

Scorpia rubbed the back of her head with one pincer. She looked overwhelmed and demoralized. "This was a mistake. We should just go back. I don't know what I was thinking."

"This is your home," Perfuma said gently, resting her hand on Scorpia's other pincer. "It only needs some love!"

Adora and Catra glanced at each other, but held their tongues for Scorpia's sake. They both knew what the other was thinking, anyway.

"Love, and an army of cleaners. Hey, maybe that's what we can have the clones do!" Bow said.

Perfuma pursed her lips slightly at this; she had Opinions on the ethics of using the clones for labor. "But once it's clean," she continued gamely, "you will be able to put your own touches on it, really make it your own!" She smiled up at Scorpia and brought her other hand up to sandwich Scorpia's pincer. "And I think you already have some ideas for that, don't you?"

Scorpia blushed deep enough to almost match her carapace. "I've never decorated before…" She started to mumble, but Catra cut her off.

"Scorp, you had the neatest room in the Horde. You just haven't ever had anything to decorate with."

Scorpia considered that for a moment. "Well, I had thought… I don't know, maybe some, uh, flowers? Would really liven the place up? Make as big a change from the Horde as possible, you know." Scorpia's blush somehow deepened, but she caught Perfuma's gaze and held it.

The rest of the group desperately tried not to look like they were smirking at each other, except Catra, who openly smirked.

"Oh I know what you need!" Frosta lept suddenly into the middle of the group. "Ice flowers!" She yelled excitedly and punched the floor with an ice fist. A trail of ice blazed across the floor and up the nearest wall, winding into surprisingly delicate crystalline flowers and vines, all made of sparkling clear or softly frosted ice.

Scorpia and Perfuma broke their eye contact to blink at the ice flowers, both clearly at a loss. Glimmer glared at Frosta and tried to make some gesture that conveyed *you're ruining the moment!* without Scorpia seeing, while Bow chuckled nervously, "Wow, Frosta, those are amazing!" His voice cracked with his false enthusiasm.

Frosta threw back her head and laughed, and the ice flowers vanished with a sparkle. "You guys should have seen your faces!" She leaned over and howled for another breath before abruptly stopping. "Seriously though, this place needs some flowers for sure, Perfuma. It is *grim* in here."

They were all sitting in a circle around one of Glimmer's campfire spells: Adora, Catra, Melog sitting on their feet, Glimmer, Bow, Scorpia, Perfuma, Frosta, Micah, Mermista, Seahawk, Netossa, Spinnerella, and even Castaspella. Only Entrapta was missing, because she had predictably gotten distracted in Hordak's old lab and had told Scorpia, who had gone to fetch her, that they should go ahead and start eating dinner without her.

The Fright Zone creaked and groaned around them. Adora felt strangely comforted by the familiar sounds. It didn't feel quite right to feel comforted, what with all the bad memories associated with that place, but just then the familiar outweighed everything else. And it helped to have all of her friends there, looking relaxed and at their ease. The utter absence of ration bars on the plate on her lap was a huge plus too.

It was only their first day of cleaning up the Fright Zone, and most of it had been spent assessing the work ahead and taking inventory. The only real work they had done was making sure the barracks and kitchens were habitable and functional for the volunteers. Most of the volunteers were former Horde soldiers putting in their service hours, but a fair number were citizens from across Etheria. Many of those were even people whose families had lived in the Fright Zone before the Horde landed, who now wanted to move back. Between the years of indifferent Horde upkeep, recent battles, and the thick mat of aggressive vegetation courtesy of She-Ra, it was going to take a lot of work to make the Fright Zone somewhere pleasant to live. But all of Etheria seemed to be feeling hopeful just then: Salineas had been fixed up good as new, followed by all of the major villages, and the Fright Zone had felt like the logical next repair project.

Adora balanced her food on her lap, eating with one had while the other was occupied with flipping through her notes from the day. From what she had seen, they had a few different options for where to start the work, but she wanted to first check with Scorpia before they made any decisions. After all, this was technically her kingdom.

Catra's shoulder nudged Adora out of her studying. "We've spent the whole day thinking about this stuff, you can't take a break even to eat?"

"I am taking a break! I was just checking on one thing…"

Catra laughed. "Adora, you were so focused on your notes that you didn't even notice you were eating my food."

Adora looked down at their plates. Hers was still half full, while Catra's was nearly bare: definitely not the usual course of their meals. "Why didn't you say something sooner?! Here, you can have the rest of mine." She tried to switch their plates, but Catra smacked her hand away.

"Don't be such a dummy, I got enough to eat already. You just put those notes down and finish what's on your plate." When Adora still hesitated, Catra rolled her eyes. "Do you really think I would let you take my food if I didn't want you to?"

Adora narrowed her eyes. "I could take it if I wanted to."

"Adora, do you have to make everything a competition?" Glimmer cut in.

"I think it's sweet that you share your food," Bow added in a too-innocent voice.

Catra glared in mock outrage at him. "I'll share the rest of my food with your face if you keep that up."

"But your plate is empty," Glimmer said with a smirk.

"Adora's isn't."

"It is now," Bow said.

Glimmer and Catra both stared at Adora's now empty plate. "Adora, do you even breathe when you eat?" Glimmer asked. Adora shrugged.

Several spots down, Micah set his plate on the floor with a clack and rubbed his hands together. "So, what's our plan for tomorrow?"

Adora quickly grabbed her notes back up, ignoring Catra's tail flipping lightly against her back, and angled herself towards Scorpia. "I identified a few areas of attack that we could start with. One, we could continue where we left off today, really

cleaning up and out the original living quarters. This would be the best place to start if you're planning on only doing surface level changes to the Fright Zone. However, if you want to make more significant changes — take it back to what it was before the Horde landed, or do your own thing with it — then I would suggest option two: starting either with the foundries or with the infrastructure. The plumbing and energy grids haven't been upgraded since the Horde arrived, which means they're well overdue for improvements. As long as we're not planning on keeping most of the existing structures — and honestly most of them are in imminent danger of collapsing — we can easily take things down to their foundations and replace the piping and wiring to your needs going forward. Similarly, I imagine you'll want to get the foundry up and running again. The Fright Zone and the rest of Etheria will definitely need the raw materials to rebuild sooner rather than later. I believe you've already been getting reports of metal shortages, right, Catra?"

"A few. Scrap from Prime's spires and all of the bots have gone a long ways, of course, but eventually that will start to run out, with all the new demand for ships and the like. The Fright Zone has the best manufacturing potential of anywhere on Etheria."

Adora nodded. "Right. But of course it is ultimately your choice, Scorpia."

Scorpia dropped her fork onto her plate with a loud clatter. "What? My choice? What do you mean?"

"This is your kingdom," Perfuma said gently, placing a hand on one of Scorpia's pincers.

Scorpia looked like she was longing for the ground to swallow her whole.

"I think you should start with the foundry," Catra volunteered. "We will probably need the raw materials to rebuild the infrastructure. And besides, Hordak and I kind of already did most of the demolition work." She rubbed the back of her neck ruefully.

“Right. Yes. Okay. Foundries sound good. A good plan.”

Adora gave her an encouraging smile and nod.

“Now that that’s sorted, who’s telling the first ghost story?” Mermista drawled.

“Uh, what?” Adora said.

Mermista shrugged. “We’ve got the campfire spell and the creepy-ass setting, it just seems like the logical thing to do.”

“Creepy?” Adora looked around at the once-familiar walls. Sure, they were starting to rust in places, and most of the lights had developed an irregular flicker, but creepy? She glanced over at Catra, who just shrugged.

“Oh, I love ghost stories!” Castaspella exclaimed. “We have some excellent ones that we tell in Mystacore.”

“You mean like the one about Light Spinner that ended up being mostly true?” Glimmer asked dryly.

“Just so!” Casta said, clapping her hands together.

Micah shifted uneasily next to her. “I don’t think those would be good ones to tell, though.”

Catra snorted. “Shadow Weaver was a whole fucking ghost story on her own.”

“Or maybe we could just sing some songs!” Perfuma suggested, a hint of desperation in her bright voice.

“Ooo, I could teach you all SEA SHANTIES!”

“Nooope.” Mermista pulled Seahawk back down from where he had lept onto a bench. “We are not doing that.”

“Adora, what about those ghost stories you kept telling us about on that one rescue mission to Aldwyn?” Glimmer asked. “The

Faceless Princess, or whatever?”

“The Headless Princess? Did you really tell them those stories?” Catra leaned back on her right arm and raised her eyebrow at Adora.

Adora flushed and opened her mouth to protest, but Bow beat her to the answer. “She never actually did tell us the stories, just teased them enough that we were scared out of our skins by every little sound.”

“Perfect,” Mermista purred.

“They’re not *too* scary, are they?” Spinnerella asked with a sideways glance towards Frosta.

Netossa smirked at her wife. “Are you trying to wimp out?”

Spinnerella frowned, a little primly. “I am simply concerned that we won’t get enough sleep tonight, if we’re all kept awake by scary stories. And we need to be rested for tomorrow.”

“Nah, they’re not that bad.” Catra cut through the impending marital competition. “Shadow Weaver started telling us them when we were, like, six.” She paused and frowned thoughtfully. “On second thought, that’s not actually saying anything, is it?”

Adora chuckled softly while Perfuma and Spinnerella shook their heads solemnly. Melog looked up from their spot on the floor and chimed something to Catra. Catra gave a small smile at whatever they said, and reached down to ruffle their head. “Thanks, buddy.”

Everyone jumped as something clanged loudly in the distance.

“Building falling down, or Entrapta?” Bow asked into the pause.

“I’m honestly not sure which of those to hope for,” Glimmer answered.

The overhead lights suddenly flickered and died in unison, leaving them in only the glow of Glimmer's campfire spell. "Entrapta," the group groaned in unison.

"Should… should we try to go find her?" Scorpia asked.

"She has Emily and Wrong Hordak with her. Most likely she's having the time of her life," Catra said.

Bow waived his tracker pad. "And if she isn't, she knows how to get in touch with us in a pinch."

"Well, now we simply *have* to have a ghost story, with this lighting!" Castaspella said happily.

Something else in the distance gave a tortured metal groan. "And with that mood music," Netossa added.

"Come on Adora, tell us about the Headless Princess!" Frosta said, her voice slightly too loud. The last words echoed around the room for a second, a faint hiss clinging to life.

"In a place like this? No, I think you should tell them the story of the Undead Princess." Catra's eyes glowed in the dim lighting. She sounded mischievous, but Adora saw a strangely tense look flash across her face as their gazes held. Melog also had a waiting kind of tension. For some reason, it seemed important to them for Adora to play along, although for the life of her she couldn't figure out why.

Adora narrowed her eyes slightly, still holding Catra's gaze. "I don't know, that one might be too scary for these Bright Mooners."

Catra's lips quirked in amusement as the circle erupted in a variety of protestations.

"Hey! We have scary stories in Bright Moon too!"

“I’m not scared, and I’m from the Land of Snows, not from Bright Moon!”

“Most of us aren’t even from Bright Moon.”

“Oh man, that one still gives me nightmares sometimes.”

Perfuma looked nervously at Scorpia. “You’ve heard it already? Is it really that scary?”

Scorpia shrugged. “I mean, I never actually heard Shadow Weaver tell it, but it made the rounds of the cadets. Who knows, maybe the real version isn’t as bad!” She frowned. “Or it could be worse. Does the real version have a robot that turns invisible, or a robot that only walked backwards?”

Adora raised her eyebrows. “Um, nope, no robots in the one that Shadow Weaver would tell.”

“Oh good. That part was the worst.”

Adora could feel Catra shaking with suppressed laughter. “What… what happened?” she asked.

Scorpia waved a pincer vaguely. “Oh, the one robot would turn invisible, and then the other one only went backwards. Which, now that I’m saying it, that doesn’t sound scary at all, but trust me it was *way* scarier in context, when Octavia was telling it.”

Catra wheezed. “Where did Octavia hear that, I wonder,” she said to Adora under her breath.

Adora snorted quietly, then inhaled a deep breath and took the plunge. “You want to know the truth about the Undead Princess?” She pitched her voice to carry, and the other conversations trailed off abruptly.

Chapter End Notes

First time posting on ao3 so bear with me as I work through the p a n i c of trying to get tagging and formatting right on the first try, because obviously it's the worst thing in the world if I don't—

The Tale of the Undead Princess

“The thing about the Undead Princess is that she doesn’t come to you, you go to her. You walk right into your own doom, and you’re happy to do it.”

Adora had the group’s attention. “Years ago, there was a scouting group that was sent out on a mission. Nothing special, just a routine information gathering and training mission. There were six of members of the team: the leader, two trackers, and three senior cadets. They left one winter morning, and a week later, one lone tracker stumbled out of the woods, barely alive, gasping the story with her last breaths.

“On the day they had left, it was a clear and cold morning. The ground sparkled with heavy frost. The air was dead calm. The frost burnt away the day broke, and it snatched at their ankles like smoke. The leader had been a Force Captain for several years at that point, and she was well used to frosty mornings like these, as were the two trackers. The three cadets, however, were still early enough in their training that it was a novel experience — and not one that they were particularly enjoying.

“They tracked all morning through the woods, encountering nothing out of the ordinary. The oldest of the cadets was feeling comfortable enough to complain out loud about the cold. Their Force Captain quickly shut down this dissent, but the trackers shared a look that said they privately agreed with the cadet’s assessment: it was, in fact, freezing. The only saving grace was the clear sky and calm air.

“In the afternoon, though, clouds began to build, gradually blocking out the moonlight. As the darkness closed in, the wind began to pick up and snow began to fall. Before they knew it, the team was in the middle of a blizzard. Everything was blinding white. There was no way to tell which direction was what, and no way to build a shelter with the howling wind.

“The team had two options: sit and freeze to death, or keep moving and hope for the best. They took their only chance, linked arms, and picked a direction to walk in. Their Captain took point, followed by the junior of the trackers, then the three cadets, then the senior tracker taking up the rear. Their whole world was nothing but a blinding wall of swirling snow, interrupted only by occasional tree trunks that would loom suddenly out of the static.

“How long did they wander? Who knows. There comes a point in situations like that when time stops having any meaning. The storm is eternal: always is, always has been, always will be. The cold eats away at you until that’s all you can notice, and you start to wish for that moment, that moment just before it devours you whole, when you know you’ll feel nothing at all.

“The wall came out of nowhere. One minute the world was nothing but raging snow, and the next their path was blocked by a stone wall. There was no way to tell how tall it was: the top disappeared into the snow. It could have stopped just above their reach, or it could have continued up for a mile. The wind hit the wall and screamed angrily off to their right.

“Which way to go? To battle the wind, or to let it carry them along? What if they had tried to fight it — would they have avoided their bitter fate, or would the storm have sealed it for them anyway? Were they doomed from the moment they left, on that frosty morning?

“They went downwind, stumbling along through unexpected drifts, keeping the wall on their left. When they reached the door, they almost didn’t notice it. The leader didn’t; she would have kept walking. But the junior tracker behind her saw it, sharp eyes catching the change, and he paused. It was flush with the wall, and just as snow-plastered as the stones around it. The only reason it stood out at all was that it was smooth, made of close-fitting boards of dark wood rather than the rough-hewn stones.

“Also, it swung open when they passed it.

“Now you, sitting here comfortably, listening to this story, may find it easy to say: ‘Don’t go in! It’s a trap!’ But I ask you, would you have walked on? Would you have been able to ignore the invitation of shelter? Would you have continued to wander, lost, through a blizzard?

“They went in, of course. The door led to a narrow stone arched passage, which opened up into a bare courtyard. Pristine snow blanketed the ground, undisturbed by any breath of wind, glittering in the lavender twilight. The moons hung in a clear sky overhead. When they turned around, the storm still howled on the other side of the passsage. But within the courtyard all was still, the unexpected silence deafening.

“The team huddled at the mouth of the passage, like mice before a cat, trying to understand what they were seeing. Three sides of the courtyard were the same stone walls as they had been following, that they could now see was as high as three people. The fourth side of the courtyard, however, rose up higher yet, windows breaking up the stone, the top biting the sky with crenelations. This was a castle.

“Another door stood in that fourth wall, opposite from the passageway, leading into the castle. This one was much larger than the one behind them, the wood smooth but studded with gleaming metal bolts. It didn’t open at their approach like the other one, but it beckoned just the same. Something about the look of it seemed to promise roaring fires and plush cushions. The party could have stayed in the courtyard, could have managed to pitch shelter there out of the wind — but what if the occupant of the castle saw? That would be rude, would it not be? They had already been offered the first threshold of hospitality; surely they would be afforded more. Besides, they might have been out of the wind, but it was still bitterly cold.

“So they steeled themselves, crossed the courtyard, and went into the castle. The huge door swung inward at a touch on silent hinges, balanced well enough that a child could have opened it, even though it had to have weighed a ton. It opened into a long

hallway lined with torches and tapestries, with woven rugs covering the smooth stone floors. The nearest torches fluttered slightly with the motion of the door, but everything else was still and silent, inviting them further in.

"They walked along the hallway, arms still linked. The tracker at the end found herself admiring the tapestries: they were embroidered in bright colors, depicting fantastic scenes of fetes, strange beasts, wild gardens, and magic feats. The style of them looked ancient, but the fabrics and threads were as fresh as if they had been finished only that morning, gleaming in the steady torchlight. The torches, too, looked fresh as a cut.

"After several minutes of walking, she turned and looked back towards where they had come from. The door they had entered through was lost in the distance, and they had yet to come across another. There was only endless torches and tapestries. Just before she could say anything, their leader stopped so suddenly that the whole line folded up.

"A door had appeared in the left-hand wall. It almost certainly hadn't been there a moment ago, or they would have seen it sooner — right? But now it was there, warm wood covered in intricate carvings that almost looked like something, that almost made sense…

"The leader put out her hand and pushed the door open. A warm glow spilled out, followed by a gentle wave of heat. It wasn't cold in the hallway, especially compared with the blizzard outside, but it also wasn't warm. Without discussion, the party piled through the door, seeking out the warmth.

"The door led to a comfortable room, with more tapestries on the walls and thick rugs on the floor. On the left side of the room ran a long table, covered with steaming plates of food. On the right side, a pile of cushions sat in front of an enormous roaring fireplace.

“They still hadn’t seen another soul other than themselves. Clearly someone lived here, and from the looks of things had just left, or was about to come back. What would they say, if they came back to the sight of a bedraggled scouting party eating their food and lounging in front of their fireplace? On the other hand… there was so much food, would they really miss some of it? And resting in front of the fireplace wouldn’t cause any harm at all…

“The food smelled glorious. They tried at first to be polite about eating, to only take a bit and eat it properly, but each bite was an epiphany, a symphony of taste. Within seconds, they were stuffing food in their mouths by the handfull. It was a long time before they felt sated enough to stop, but the table still looked as full of food as it had when they first walked in.

“They turned to rest for the night in front of the fireplace, and suddenly noticed that the youngest cadet was missing.

“They looked around the room, but there was no place that the missing cadet could be hiding in the room. They rushed out into the hallway, but it was empty. When was the last time they had seen him? He had come into the room with them, hadn’t he? He had eaten with them hadn’t he? The party stood at the doorway and looked at each other, each seeing the same realization in the others’ eyes: they couldn’t remember.

“‘Welcome,’ said a voice from back inside the room. The scouting party whirled as one, not quite behaving like the well-trained soldiers they supposedly were.

“A beautiful woman had appeared suddenly, standing gracefully by the far corner of the table. She had long, flowing black hair, eyes like chips of onyx, and a wide mouth with deep red lips, all more striking against her paper-white skin. She was dressed in a flowing, floor-length white robe edged with black embroidery, which opened at the waist to reveal elegant legs covered in tight black pants. She smiled, revealing perfect white teeth. ‘I am sorry I was not able to greet you sooner.’ Her melodious voice contained the faintest trace of an unidentifiable accent, just slightly rounding

her vowels and stretching her consonants, turning her simple statement into a sonnet.

"The scouting party — minus one cadet — stared at her, frozen in shock and no small amount of fascination. The woman continued to simply stand, smiling calmly as though being mutely stared at by strangers was the normal way to be greeted in one's own home. Perhaps it was, when one lived alone in a castle, and looked like *that*.

"The leader of the team finally found her voice. 'We are sorry to have trespassed on your home. We were only seeking shelter from the storm.'

"The beautiful woman smiled kindly. 'Of course you are welcome. Do not trouble yourselves.'

"The leader nodded an awkward thanks. The etiquette for this kind of situation had strangely been missing from her Force Captain Orientation. She cleared her throat. 'We seem to have lost one of our party. Have you by chance seen him?'

"Their hostess arched her perfect eyebrows. 'Oh dear! I am sure he has simply availed himself of the washroom.' She raised one hand and gestured elegantly towards a side door beyond the table that none of them had noticed before. 'I am sure he will rejoin you soon. In the meantime, please do continue to rest and recuperate. Your journey through the blizzard could not have been easy.'

"The trackers blinked hard at the door she had gestured towards. How had they missed seeing yet another door? How many other doors in that castle had they missed? But their hostess smiled benevolently at them, and the fire glowed warmly, and their bellies were wonderfully full, and suddenly-appearing doors just didn't seem like the most pressing issue at that moment. The cushions in front of the fireplace beckoned, and they willingly surrendered themselves to their exhaustion. In hindsight, this was of course a mistake.

"The fire was still burning brightly when they awoke. It felt like morning, but there weren't any windows in the room to judge by. The table was piled high with new food, and the scents wafted enticingly towards them. The cadet was still missing, and now a second was also gone. The Force Captain and her senior tracker crossed the room to the door that led to the washroom, which none of them had tried to open the night before. It swung open, as easily as every other door they had encountered in the castle, into a gleaming space. All of the normal bathroom appliances were present, but they were all formed from some kind of white stone with gold flecks in it. The floor was tiled in the same material, and the walls were covered in tiles that looked the same but with teal streaks running through it. A stack of fluffy towels stood on a shelf opposite the sink, and there appeared to be a variety of soaps to choose from on the vanity — although why they would need more than one soap option escaped them. The only thing the bathroom didn't contain was the two missing cadets.

"'Good morning.' Their hostess' song-like voice interrupted their inspection of the washroom. 'I trust you spent the night comfortably?' They turned to find her once more standing by the corner of the table.

"'Yes, thank you, but now we are missing another cadet,' The leader said, a little curtly. Now that she had slept, she was finding the situation more concerning.

"Their hostess smiled, her teeth gleaming like the stone in the washroom. 'Oh, you must have just missed them! They have gone to avail themselves of our training area. It is so refreshing to see young people be so dedicated to their work, is it not?' She swept a hand towards the laden table. 'But please, do partake of some breakfast before you go to join them. You are welcome here as long as you wish. There is no reason to rush.'

"The remaining four looked at each other. The food did smell delicious. 'Thank you, hostess,' the leader answered after a moment.

“Her smile grew wider. ‘Please, it is my pleasure.’

“The senior tracker paused before she started eating. ‘Er, where is the training area?’ She asked their host. She tried to look their hostess in her eyes, as was probably polite, but found herself addressing her question to an embroidered collar instead, her eyes catching there and refusing to travel further upwards.

“‘It is back out the hall, to the left, then straight on. You can’t miss it.’ Their hostess turned and walked through the doorway to point the way, her steps so smooth she almost looked like she was gliding. The skirt of her robe flared behind her. The sight was bewitching, the movement somehow impossible to look away from.

“The last remaining cadet was the first to recover. She turned back to the laden table and grumbled, ‘Well I don’t want to rush off to train.’

“The other three glared at her, but their hostess laughed merrily. ‘I of course cannot countermand your commander’s orders, should she choose to make you train after such a long day as you had yesterday, but I for one would not think the less of you, should you remain here to rest.’ She winked conspiratorially, long eyelashes briefly fanning against one marble cheek. Then she turned and left, gliding right from the doorway.

“They ate their fill of breakfast. Once they finished, the remaining cadet made herself comfortable in front of the fire. ‘I am going to stay right here,’ she announced defiantly.

“The leader and the trackers exchanged glances. ‘I don’t like splitting the party up further,’ one of the trackers said in a low voice.

“‘Cadets,’ the other said with disgust.

“The Force Captain sighed. ‘Alright, you will stay here,’ she said to the cadet. ‘But under no circumstances are you to leave this room,

you hear me? That's an order. We are going to go find your two fellow cadets and bring them back here.'

"The remaining cadet agreed willingly and settled in deeper into the cushions. She looked so comfortable that the junior tracker looked back longingly, wishing he could stay in front of the fireplace and not go searching down the errant cadets.

"They left the warmth of the room and turned left down the hallway, following their beautiful hostess' instructions. The tapestries on the walls seemed even more vivid now than they had looked the night before, and the scenes on them grew ever more fantastical as they marched down the hallway. The senior tracker finally stopped in front of one to stare. It showed a shining black dragon circling over a bright white hill. The lines of the dragon were crisp against the pale lavender sky, but the hill looked oddly blurred. She leaned closer, then recoiled. The hill was a massive pile of bones. Whoever had made this tapestry had taken the time to painstakingly detail the outline of each one, femurs and ribs and skulls and spines. All of them looked human.

"'Where is everyone?' She asked as she tore her gaze away.

"The other tracker looked at her. 'We're going to find them, remember?'

"She shook her head impatiently. 'No, I mean all of the other people who live here. There was all that food, who made it? Who keeps everything here so clean? Surely this whole place can't be for only one person, so where are the rest of the people who live here? Why have we only seen that one woman? And… who is she?'

"'Maybe she likes being alone, and all of her servants know to stay out of sight.' The other tracker shrugged. He didn't seem concerned.

"Their leader glanced back over her shoulder at the two of them. 'We'll leave as soon as we have found the other two cadets and

regrouped. The storm will probably have died down by now, and we can head back to base.'

"The hallway turned and ended abruptly in a dead end. A large tapestry hung on the wall in their way, depicting a woman who bore a striking resemblance to their hostess. She was floating on a background of red, black hair floating all around her head, black-edged white robes covering her from shoulder to ankle, her arms outstretched. In her right hand, she held a chalice. In her left, she held a pale-bladed dagger. The figure's eyes appeared to have been sewn with actual chips of onyx. 'I'm getting a bad feeling from all of this,' the senior tracker said.

"The other tracker shrugged again. 'I don't know, it just shows that she's fierce. You know, don't mess with her. Probably when you live alone you come up with some weird things.' He tilted his head, looking at the tapestry with admiration.

"The leader turned around and stared back down the hallway. 'Where are all of the doors? Why is this just a hallway that leads nowhere? We followed her instructions exactly, and this is all we find?' She whirled back to the tapestry of the woman. 'Is there a door behind it?'

"They pulled the tapestry aside. A door sat flush with the wall. It was made of some kind of black wood and covered in gilt etchings, swirls and fanciful curlicues of gold. The door latch was a miniature ivory skull. 'Are there doors behind all of the tapestries?' Exclaimed the junior tracker.

"The senior tracker rolled her eyes. 'The others don't go all the way to the floor, remember?'

"Her colleague folded his arms defensively. 'The doors could be up off the ground, too.'

"'Shut up, you two,' the leader said. 'Do we go through this door? I have a funny feeling that it doesn't lead to the training area.'

“The two trackers looked at each other. ‘It’s clearly private. We shouldn’t go poking around somewhere that was deliberately hidden,’ the junior tracker said.

“’Do we have another option for where to go?’ The senior pointed out.

“‘Back to the room with the food and the fireplace?’

“The leader reached out her hand and touched the skull latch, and the door eagerly swung open outwards. Sharp-edged light sprang in through the gap. All three blinked in the unexpected brightness, momentarily blinded. It hadn’t seemed that dim in the hallway before. Once they could see again, they cautiously approached the threshold.

“The door opened over a courtyard, several feet off the ground. The sky above was clear, bright daylight illuminating the scene. At first they thought it was snow that covered the ground in a blanket of white. Then their eyes adjusted. It wasn’t snow covering the ground: it was bones. Hundreds of bones, all clean and bleached, filling the courtyard in whorls and eddies of ivory.

“‘Do you like my collection?’ They whirled around. Their hostess stood behind them, proudly looking past them at the courtyard. ‘I have more than anyone else. Not even my grandmother had this many.’ She smiled, her mouth too wide. ‘And I shall delight in adding yours to my collection.’ Her mouth continued to stretch, revealing sharp white shark teeth — and too many of them. She reached towards them, and her hands were skeletally thin, the skin dull and waxy pale, the fingers ending in yellowing fingernails that sharpened to jagged points. She grabbed the male tracker by the shoulders, and in her ravenous triumph, let her illusions fall away entirely.

“The hallway and beautiful tapestries and rugs tore away like smoke before a gale, replaced with rough cave walls, dark and dank. The doorway overlooking the courtyard of bones became a rough fissure that opened into a sinkhole that was open to the sky

— and still filled with bones. And the woman herself… The skeletal hands and the sharp teeth were now the prettiest things about her. Her bright white robe was nothing but bleached rags, color leached away by time. Her hair hung in tangled, matted clumps. Her eyes were cloudy marbles sunken into her face, which on second look appeared to be missing some skin, revealing stringy muscle and yellowed bone.

"'I do so love when fresh meat walks into my lair,' the Undead Princess said, and then she ate the tracker.

"The leader and the remaining tracker ran. The only way out was to either go past the Undead Princess as she happily snacked on their fellow, or to dive into the sea of bones. They took their chances running back down the hallway. The princess continued eating, not even trying to stop them as they went, but her sibilant chuckle pursued them as they ran.

"The cave passage went on and on, and they could only follow it, stumbling in the dark. Finally, there was a hint of light at the end of the passage: just a slight grey tint to the distance. At the same time that that appeared, though, they heard the sounds of something behind them. Something that wasn't quite footsteps, but wasn't quite slithering: something in between. Something coming after them, and not worried about either hiding or rushing. Something confident in its catch.

"The leader tripped over a rock and went down hard. The surviving tracker stopped to help her up, but the leader pushed her away. 'No. We aren't going to make it — not both of us. I'll hold her off, you… you go get help.'

"The tracker looked back along the cave, and saw a figure in the distance. It was moving towards them with a horrible, spider-like speed. She looked back down at her leader struggling on the cave floor, then turned and ran. She was within sight of the exit, could see the outside world coming into focus, when the screams started echoing up behind her; and she kept running, all the way through the woods, wading through snow, back to base. She

made her report to her shocked superiors, and then dropped dead of exhaustion and fear.

"Of course, parties were sent out the next day, and more in the weeks that followed, to try to find the castle or caves that the tracker claimed contained the Undead Princess. None of them were successful… but not all of the parties returned, either. The search was called off, but ever since, every few years, a few soldiers go mysteriously missing around a certain part of the Whispering Woods, never to been seen again."

The Tale of the Headless Princess

The group stared at Adora.

"She told that story to *children?*" Castaspella said, finally breaking the silence.

Adora looked around at everyone's faces, suddenly fighting the urge to shrink into herself. She thought she had done a good job telling the story, but now…

"That was so creepy!" Frosta exclaimed, looking delighted.

"Was that how it really goes? Oh wow, that is so much different from the version that Octavia told," Scorpia said, and everyone else started talking at once.

Right, of course the stories that Shadow Weaver told them growing up in the Horde would be much different from what the rest of the Alliance had grown up with. She knew that. She *knew* that. Bow and Glimmer had even told her some of the stories they had grown up with: The Picky Princess, The Velveteen Kowl, The Little Sea-Elf. Cute stories in which nobody got eaten.

"Hey," Catra said quietly in her ear, under the cover of all the chatter. "You okay?"

Adora forced her face into a smile. "Yeah, of course!" And the story was *supposed* to be creepy, she reminded herself.

Catra just looked at her, and Melog made a quiet noise.

Adora let her shoulders and smile sag. "Why did I tell that one?"

And of course Catra understood what she was really asking. "They were all bad. And besides, I made you tell that one. It's…" She trailed off and looked around the circle. Everyone was still talking, discussing the story with their neighbors. "Look, our childhood was messed up. You know that. I know that. Everyone here

knows that, even if they don't know exactly how messed up." Adora snorted. "Maybe it's good to get some of that out into the open. I don't know." She rubbed Adora's back. "And I have to say, babe, you might be a terrible actor, but you tell that story even better than Shadow Weaver did."

Adora brightened. "You think?"

"Ok now you have to tell the Headless Princess one!" Glimmer said excitedly, grabbing Adora's arm.

"Oh, I don't know…" Adora said, and she glanced around the circle to gauge everyone's reactions. To her surprise, they mostly seemed interested — or even excited.

Catra leaned back in towards her. "They're our stories now," she said softly.

Adora smiled at her. She liked that idea, that they could claim back some of their childhood, and remake it how they wanted. She cleared her throat and raised her voice to be heard over the chatter. "I don't know if I should tell that one. We might wake her up."

The group quieted instantly and held their breath in anticipation. "Wake who up?" Mermista asked after a beat, a small smile playing on her lips; her sense of the dramatic was honed to perfection.

"The Headless Princess," Adora answered in a whisper.

"Wake her up?" Scorpia squeaked in alarm.

Adora nodded seriously. "It's happened before. The village of Alcinor woke her up."

Glimmer frowned. "There is no village of Alcinor."

"Anymore," Adora said in the most foreboding voice she could muster.

“Alcinor used to be a thriving village, much like Erlandia. It sat on the edge of the Whispering Woods… maybe a little *too* close to the woods.

“The first hint that something had gone wrong came when all of their birds disappeared: one day, the village and surrounding woods were full of the normal, happily chirping birds. The next morning, the villagers awoke to a strange silence. It took them a little while to figure it out. The absence of something is often harder to notice than its presence.

“Once they did figure it out, it was almost impossible to *not* notice it. Where did all of the birds go? The sky was clear, the moons drifting lazily through the cloudless lavender, so the birds weren’t hiding from the weather. It was late spring, and there was plenty of food for them to eat around the village, so they hadn’t left because of that.

“The day went on, and they learned that only Alcinor was affected, only in the village itself and its immediate surroundings. The other villages still had all their birds, present and audibly accounted for. It was weird that the birds were gone, but what could be done about it? And so they continued on with their day as usual.

“As evening closed in, they almost didn’t notice that the silence continued: none of the evening bugs started up their usual buzzings and hummings.

“The town elders called a meeting of the village the next morning. Everyone showed up, from the oldest resident to the newest baby. The only person missing was the village’s resident crotchety old man, who lived alone in the house closest to the Whispering Woods — practically under their branches — and he never showed up for things anyway, if he could help it. They all met and discussed what had happened, and what to do about it. The problem was, of course, that nothing had actually *happened*. They

were just missing some birds and bugs. So, there wasn't anything that anyone could figure out to do. Not that this stopped them from discussing endlessly what they *could* do, what they *might* do, what they *would* do, what the worst case scenario might be, and so on, until the entire village was out of breath and on edge, without any progress having been made. Eventually the meeting only broke up because people had work to get back to.

"That evening arrived even more quiet than the one before, as even the wind died down to nothing. None of the bright new leaves on the trees stirred, nothing rustled through the growing grasses and bushes on the ground. Even the moons felt hushed, more distant, drawing thin clouds over themselves like they were feeling shy. To the people in Alcinor, huddled superstitiously in their homes, it felt like they had become detached from the rest of Etheria, an island of silence all on their own. It was the kind of quiet that you wanted desperately to be broken, but you equally desperately didn't want to be the one to break it.

"It broke just after the last light faded from the sky. Everyone was so attuned to the maddening silence by then that the first shuffling steps sounded like the dream of a shout. In a way, it was a relief that the biting silence had been disturbed. Their ears had been straining unconsciously for so long for something to grasp onto; but once they grasped onto the sound of those footsteps, they all found themselves desperately wishing for the silence to return.

"Objectively, there was nothing obviously wrong with the sound of those footsteps: maybe they were a little too hesitant, maybe a little too dragging, but they should have sounded like anybody out walking out of the woods, along the dirt path of the village, in the dark.

"They didn't.

"The sound tugged at their ears, at their minds, asking questions of the night. Each step landed like sandpaper on bare skin, coyly flaying strips off their sanity. Most of the villagers curled up tighter

in their beds, stuffing their heads under their pillows, but a few brave — or foolhardy — individuals twitched aside curtains to peer out into the night.

"Whatever was making those footsteps, it seemed like even the moons were avoiding it. The few watchers strained their eyes, trying to sort out shadows from some denser darkness. Finally they were rewarded as a thin shaft of moonlight broke through in just the right spot.

"The figure was cloaked in dark, rusty brown, a tattered hem barely clearing the ground obscuring the feet treading those grating footsteps. On first impression, the outline of the figure seemed strangely distorted, like something viewed distantly through a heat-haze. Then the moonlight, in the manner of someone making a brilliant repartee before jumping out of a window, gleefully illuminated the bloody stump of the figure's neck, where its head should have been and manifestly no longer was, and danced along the ashen grey arms reaching out, the hands in the lead, grasping, searching, *wanting*.

"What would you do when the dead come walking? I'll tell you what the villagers of Alcinor did: they locked their doors, barricaded their windows, and wished desperately to wake up from that shuffling nightmare.

"Morning came, and never before had the inevitable felt so generous. It still dawned without birdsong, but also without any *other* sounds. Villagers cautiously emerged from their homes with their faces haggard from lack of sleep and excess of fear. A few — mostly those who had peered out into the darkness — looked as though they had aged a full year during the night. They looked at each other, and saw their fears reflected in their neighbors' faces, saw that they hadn't imagined whatever had happened.

"Some of the doors stayed closed, though, no timid villager poking their head out to taste the morning air; and when neighbors knocked on their doors, nobody answered. Instead, those doors

swung limply open, as if they knew they had failed their one chief purpose.

"Those homes were empty. The villagers who should have been there to answer the doors, who had started the night behind them, had vanished. The only sign of anything amiss was the footprints on the floor, bold stamps of slowly oxidizing red.

"And the villagers knew. They all packed up and left Alcinor that very same day; nobody wanted to spend another night in that place. They left, spreading the word: the Headless Princess had emerged from the Whispering Woods in search of a new head, and she wouldn't stop until she was satisfied."

Adora finished and looked around the circle of wide-eyed faces.

"Did she ever find her head?" Bow asked in a hushed voice.

Adora shrugged. "No one ever resettled Alcinor… or at least, no one resettled there and lived to tell about it."

"How did she lose her head in the first place?" Frosta asked.

"No one knows for sure, of course. The common assumption is that there was some battle that she was in, where she lost it. Or, possibly, something more personal than a battle: a lover's quarrel that turned deadly, or an assassination." Adora leaned forward. "But my favorite theory? It was a magical experiment that went wrong, and her real head actually *was* still out there somewhere."

Glimmer chuckled. "What kind of experiment would do that?" She wondered.

Castaspella looked thoughtful. "I can think of a few students in Mystacore who were in danger of doing worse than that."

Micah snorted. "Magic students are worse than babies when it comes to self-destructive behavior. You tell them not to do

something, and they have to try it the very next chance they get. It's frankly a wonder that more heads haven't been lost."

"Wait, are we saying that the Headless Princess is a plausible story?" Perfuma asked, her voice rising in disbelief.

"A corpse that's missing its head but still running around? Seems unlikely," Netossa said.

Catra tilted her head thoughtfully. "Magic can do some freaky shit."

The lights in the room flickered briefly, not quite coming back on before going dark once more. At the same time, an eerie sound floated past. It was a little like someone crying, and a little like someone laughing, and not very much like either. Adora felt the hairs on her arms raise.

"Okay, what was that?" Frosta asked, her eyes as big as saucers. "Was that a normal Fright Zone sound? Tell me that was a normal Fright Zone sound."

"Uhhh…" Adora looked over at Scorpia, who looked just as freaked out as everyone else.

"That sounded like the Weeping Princess," Catra said, her voice nonchalant. Her posture was also striving for casual, but Adora could feel how tense she was. Tense, but not freaked out.

"The Weeping Princess?" Scorpia gasped.

"Last time Adora thought it was the Weeping Princess, it was just a hologram," Bow said.

Adora sat forward to glare at him indignantly. "I didn't think that was the Weeping Princess, I just said that it reminded me of the story of the Weeping Princess."

"Ugh, just tell the story of the Weeping Princess already," Mermista groaned.

The Tale of The Weeping—

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora didn't want to tell the story of the Weeping Princess, she wanted to find out what was going on with Catra. She knew Catra, and she knew that Catra was acting… off. Being back in the Fright Zone was weird for all of the former Horde kids, but it would be especially hard for Catra. But Catra herself didn't seem to want to talk about it. She was the one who kept bringing up the stories, and encouraging Adora to tell them. Adora didn't want to tell the story, but if Catra wanted her to, she would.

"Are you sure you want to hear about the Weeping Princess?" She asked the assembled group. "The Headless Princess can be scared off, but nothing gets between the Weeping Princess and her target." Everyone stared at her with rapt attention. That answered that question, then.

"The Weeping Princess started as a normal princess. She lived centuries ago in a small kingdom in the forest, before it grew into the Whispering Woods. What her powers originally were, no one knows, but she began experimenting with powers over light. She worked on creating it, and destroying it, and bending it, and more. She was almost never successful, but she kept trying.

"Her people and the other princesses indulged this. After all, what harm could light do? And they would chuckle to themselves, imagining the benefits: no more stubbed toes when you get up in the middle of the night to go to the restroom! No more moonlight sneaking through that one little crack in the curtains right where it would hit you in the eyes! The wizards in Mystacor already had light illusions and of course basic lighting spells. What more could a princess have to offer?

“The answer, it turned out, was a lot more, once she figured out the basics. Maybe she asked a wizard for help, or maybe she eventually cracked it herself, but either way: one day her entire kingdom woke up to darkness.

“We think we know what darkness is. It’s dark at night, it’s dark in closets, it’s dark when you close your eyes. What her kingdom experienced that day was not simply darkness, but the absence of light. It only lasted through the morning, but tales of that darkness spread throughout Etheria and were passed down through generations.

“That was the most dramatic display of her powers that the public ever saw, and it probably wasn’t even on purpose. But after that, rumors of strange happenings from the castle started to whisper across the kingdom and Etheria. Most people dismissed these as the castle staff trying to capitalize on the drama that the great darkness produced, but a few of the more curious types came to see for themselves what was happening with the princess who was experimenting with light.

“Among those curious few was a general from a neighboring kingdom, who was fascinated by the potential military applications of such a power. She travelled to work with the princess, to find ways that her new powers could be helpful — and to convince her to use them in those ways. We know from reports that she sent back that she made contact with the princess, and that they started working together, that they built a rapport. The reports never included any specific details, in case they were intercepted, so we have no record of what exactly happened. What we do know is that, about a year into their collaboration, something went very wrong.

“The first sign that something had happened came one spring morning when the village cobbler went up to the castle to drop off a few pairs of repaired boots. The castle gate was closed, and no one answered when he hailed. Eventually he gave up and went back down to the village, grumbling the whole way. He passed a troupe of popular travelling entertainers who were on their way up

to the castle, and complained to them about the treatment he had received.

"The entertainers arrived to find the gates still closed and still unwatched. Unlike the cobbler, they tried opening the gates themselves, and found that they were unlocked. The troupe walked into the courtyard with some trepidation. They called out to announce their arrival, but still no one showed up to greet them or throw them out. In fact, no one showed up at all. The courtyard was deserted. No one was on watch, no one was cleaning, no one was passing through from one part of the castle to another.

"It wasn't the troupe's first time visiting that castle, so they proceeded to the outbuildings where they had been housed on previous visits. The whole way there, they didn't see a single other soul. They did, however, constantly have the feeling of being watched, like there was someone just out of sight, behind them maybe, right in the corner of their eye. Most of the troupe was all for turning right back around then and there, and leaving. Something was definitely wrong at the castle.

"The troupe leader convinced them to at least put down their bags and go looking through the main castle. All of the people who lived there couldn't all simply disappear overnight; they must be somewhere about. So they set off to look for the castle occupants. And if some of the entertainers were grasping weapons, well, can you blame them?

"The main castle was just as deserted as the outbuildings. The feeling of being watched was even stronger, though. By the time they reached the great hall, the troupe was travelling in a tight clump, everyone trying to keep their backs to each other, facing outwards. Those who hadn't grabbed weapons found themselves wishing dearly that they had. The only sounds in the usually bustling castle were their own shuffling feet and nervous breathing, both of which echoed unnaturally loud against the stone walls.

“When they first heard the sound, it was so faint they could almost pretend they had imagined it. It was just the ghost of a cry, the kind of distant keening that you hear more in the prickling of the hairs on the back of your neck than in the actual sound, your body warning you of the threat before your brain can process it. The troupe froze —“

Adora broke off as a wailing cry echoed through the vents of the Fright Zone.

“Okay, that was creepy,” Mermista said after it died away. “Good timing, Adora.”

Adora opened her mouth to answer, even though she didn’t know what to say, when there was a loud sound like an inverted explosion. Catra tensed next to her like she was about to leap up.

“Should… should someone go check on Entrapta?” Spinnerella asked, looking concerned.

“Nah, she’ll let us know if she needs something,” Catra said. Adora did a double take at how relaxed her voice sounded, in contrast to how tense she still was.

Micah frowned. “Unless she can’t let us know, for instance if she’s been knocked out.”

Adora watched Catra’s jaw flex before she answered. “She has Wrong Hordak and Emily with her.”

“Those two aren’t exactly known for their sensibilities,” Glimmer said dryly. “I can just go pop in and —“

“She also probably has Hordak with her,” Catra added shortly, biting off her words.

Adora watched this news land on the group. It wasn’t like Hordak wasn’t allowed to be around, exactly, but he was still a pretty sticky topic. Mermista especially looked put off by this.

“Maybe I should —“ Scorpia started to say, when the cry echoed through the vents again. It was louder this time, and more clearly not any sound that Entrapta would make.

At the same time, Adora felt a weird tugging sensation, like half of her body was being pulled in a different direction. Not up or down, but *out* somehow, like towards a… “Catra, what is Entrapta doing?”

Catra looked at her, and Adora watched her expression go from intentionally blasé to a slight frown to actual concern as she focused on whatever she saw on Adora’s face. Before Catra could answer, though, her tracker pad beeped loudly, followed by Entrapta’s voice blasting into the room.

“CATRA! WE’VE GOT IT! My original calculations were slightly off but—“ Whatever else Entrapta said was lost to the rest of the group, because Catra and Melog had lept up and sprinted out of the room as soon as she started talking.

Everyone else sat frozen in surprise for a moment. Then everyone reacted at once. Adora lept up to follow Catra, but Glimmer grabbed her arm. Before Adora could shake her off, she felt the familiar buzzing sensation of Glimmer’s teleportation magic revving up. The next moment they landed in Hordak’s old lab, and the yelling voices of the Rebellion leaders was replaced with the sickeningly familiar roaring sound of a portal.

Chapter End Notes

> *Benoit Blanc voice* Well you see now, sometimes it's the stories *themselves* that are haunted.

Entrapta-ning

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Three weeks after the end of the war

Catra stopped in the doorway of Entrapta's new lab in Bright Moon, her hand tightening on the handle of the basket she was carrying. The lab didn't look anything like Hordak's sanctum in the Fright Zone — it was all bright warm light and graceful arches, filled with Entrapta's usual jumble of boxes and shiny metal indescribables — but it had the same smells of metal, grease, and ozone that put Catra on edge. She could hear Entrapta somewhere inside, chattering excitedly. Without being able to see her, it was impossible for Catra to tell if she was talking into her recorder, to Emily, to Hordak, or even just to herself. Catra gave herself a mental shake and walked in.

"Catra!" Entrapta crowed from behind her mask, looking up from a jumble of wires heaped across the table in front of her. Next to her, Emily jumped with an alarmed series of beeps and tried to hide behind a box. "Oh Emily, she apologized, remember?" Entrapta patted the robot and flipped her mask up with a strand of hair to look at Catra face on. "Sorry, I think you just startled her!"

Catra did her best to unclench her jaw. "It's okay. I… I promise I won't hurt you, Emily." That felt like such a pathetic promise to have to make, but she had brought this all on herself, hadn't she?

Emily beeped uncertainly but came out from behind the box. Progress.

"Did you need something?" Entrapta asked.

"I just came to check on you. You missed dinner again."

Glimmer had given Entrapta the lab space in Bright Moon so that she could continue her work, but under supervision. She still had her lab in Dryl, of course, but any experiments using First Ones technology or the wealth of new clone technology had to be done in Bright Moon, by the compromise that the Princesses had worked out. Also, Bright Moon was the only lab that Hordak was allowed to work in, and even that had been a *massive* compromise. The downside of Bright Moon for Entrapta, though, was that she wasn't used to having to stop for dinner. In Dryl, her army of robots had taken care of that for her. As her robots were confined to the lab area in Bright Moon, Emily excepted — "Missed dinner? But it's…" Entrapta stopped and pulled out her data pad. "Emily! We missed dinner!"

Catra held out the basket. "We figured you had just gotten distracted, and that you hadn't, you know, launched yourself into another dimension or something."

One of Entrapta's pigtails reached out and plucked the basket from Catra's grasp. "Ooo, so cute!" she exclaimed, peeking inside. "I don't anticipate being launched into another dimension, but you never know what might happen with portals!"

Catra's stomach knotted. She wondered if she would ever get over… "You're experimenting with portals again? Does Sparkles know?"

"She approved it! Mostly! And really, now we have so much more information than last time. And the planet isn't blocking us anymore either! So really it's almost perfectly safe!" Entrapta twirled around on the ends of her hair.

"Almost?" Catra was too familiar with Entrapta's experiments to ignore this qualifier.

"Well, there is always the *slight* chance that we could create a black hole instead of a portal." Entrapta didn't look at all frightened by this possibility — quite the opposite, in fact. "But

don’t worry! Even if it did, it would probably burn out in a fraction of a second!”

For some reason, Catra didn’t feel particularly reassured by this, but there wasn’t much she could do about it. “What are you experimenting on with portals?” She asked instead.

“I’m testing the compatibility of portals and magic!!” Entrapta jumped and spread her arms wide in her excitement. “Come see!”

Catra followed deeper into the lab as Entrapta used her hair to propel herself over to a large set of screens. She thought she could see some of Bow’s design input in the screens: they were more rounded and somehow *friendlier* looking than the screens in the Fright Zone. The graphs and text on them meant nothing to her, but Entrapta gestured towards them anyway. “Even though they *seem* like they might be similar, portals and the teleportation magic that Glimmer does are completely different! Portals are more like folding a paper, right?” Catra nodded gamely, not quite following and feeling strongly that she had been dropped in the middle of an explanation instead of the beginning, but she knew that Entrapta was doing her best. “While what Glimmer does is more like what electrons do!”

“Like what do?” Catra couldn’t even pretend to understand that.

“Electrons! They’re *teeny tiny* particles that are part of what make up everything! *And,* sometimes they are in two places at once! Well, theoretically.”

Catra tried to picture that and failed. “How is that like Glimmer’s teleportation powers?”

Entrapta rubbed her chin thoughtfully. “It’s not really a perfect comparison. But the best that I can tell, part of the Moonstone’s power is that its, well, power is everywhere on Etheria, so Glimmer *herself* is kind of in a way *also* everywhere on Etheria at once, since she’s connected to the Moonstone! So to teleport, she

just pulls on the place where she wants to go, where she sort of *already is!*"

"I thought it was just magic," Catra said. Her head ached from trying to follow.

"Oh it *is* magic!" Entrapta crowed excitedly. "I am merely trying to explain what is *physically* happening. Really you're right, it is all just magic — but that doesn't mean it can't be studied *for science!*"

Hearing Entrapta say her favorite phrase made Catra feel slightly better. "So, have you learned anything yet?"

Entrapta danced on her toes, eyes wide and shining. "Ooooo, *so much*. You wouldn't be*lieve* how much data I was able to collect just from the Spires! While we here on Etheria were stuck in Despondos, the rest of the universe made *huge* progress on portal technology. What they have out there now makes our old First Ones technology look like *children's toys*. They even solved the problem of how to close portals without trapping someone inside!"

Catra's stomach dropped off a cliff, and her vision swooped wildly. Even after a couple years and a bunch of additional trauma added to her mountain of traumas, thinking about that first portal still tipped her towards a panic attack. She hadn't *meant* to trap Angella, she hadn't meant to trap *anyone,* she had just wanted everything to *stop,* she didn't know what would happen, that she would almost trap *Adora* instead…

"Catra?" Entrapta's voice warbled slowly into focus. "Are you alright?"

Catra blinked rapidly, trying to bring the world back into focus. "I'm fine," she said sharply, then paused and breathed deep. Entrapta's concerned face swam into view, rather higher up than Catra had expected. "I… sorry." She swallowed hard and willed the ringing in her ears to go away. "I didn't mean to snap at you. I still, um, struggle with that. The. You know." She realized that she

was sitting on the floor, her back curled up against a box. *That's just your body trying to protect you from what it perceives is a threat,* she heard Perfuma's voice in her head. *It's nothing to be ashamed of!* She took another deep breath.

Entrapta crouched down in front of her, far enough away that Catra didn't feel crowded. "I didn't mean to make you panic," she said with deliberate gentleness.

Catra smiled weakly. She knew that Entrapta didn't have a mean bone in her body. "I know. It wasn't your fault." She took a third deep, deliberate breath. A tiny cake with pink icing appeared suddenly under her nose, pinched delicately between two purple locks of hair. She recognized it as one of the ones that she had brought in the basket for Entrapta. Something tight in her chest relaxed slightly, and she accepted the cake. "Thank you." The burst of sweetness on her tongue was surprisingly grounding.

Entrapta smiled, popped a tiny cake with purple icing into her own mouth, and chewed thoughtfully. "Sometimes I feel quite badly about things, too," she said slowly, after she swallowed.

"You do?" Catra said in surprise, then winced at how that sounded. "Sorry, I didn't mean…"

Entrapta waved away her apology. "No, you're right, I know I don't show it. Emotions are… hard for me. But I know that making mistakes is part of scientific advancement! And…" She shrugged and finished in the most gentle voice that Catra had ever heard from her, "all I can do now is try to make things better."

Catra sighed and let her head fall back against the box behind her. "I *wish* I could go back and undo things that I've done. But… I can't." She lifted one shoulder in a half-shrug and sighed. "And sometimes it's just so hard to live with that knowledge, you know? Like knowing that I trapped Glimmer's mom between dimensions, *forever*."

“Aaactually,” Entrapta said slowly, “I think I might have a theory about that.”

Catra brought her head sharply back upright. “What do you mean?”

Entrapta grinned and thrust her pigtails wildly out to the sides, her mood flipping instantly with the prospect of explaining more science, even to as poor an audience as Catra. “I haven’t talked with anyone about this yet — except Hordak, of course.” (Catra snorted to herself, thinking about what the other princesses would think of that.) “But looking at the clones’ portal technology, I think that it would be *theoretically* possible to *redo* that portal.”

“That is *definitely not* a good idea,” Catra said quickly, an edge of panic returning. “Opening that portal once was more than enough.”

“No no, not like that! I mean…” Entrapta stopped and bit her lip with a frown, clearly working out how she could explain it to Catra. “We reopen that same portal, but using newer and more stable tech. Theoretically, that would reopen the same, ah, doorway, if you will, between the dimensions, *but,* with the new tech we could then close it again from the outside!”

Catra stared at her. “You’re saying… we could get Angella out? Even without Adora’s old sword?”

“Yes! I mean, maybe! I can’t be sure, of course, but my theories point toward it being possible. I just have to work out *how.*”

Catra felt light-headed, but for once not with panic. This felt more like… hope? She cleared her suddenly tight throat. “Entrapta? If you can really figure that out, we *have* to try. Just…” She pressed her lips together tightly for a moment. “I don’t think we should tell anyone about this. Not yet. In case it doesn’t work. I don’t want to, you know, disappoint them.” She rubbed a nervous hand over her head, her claws running through her still-short hair. “Or in Adora’s case, trying to take on all the blame herself. Again.”

Entrapta nodded seriously. "I had thought of that as well. I wasn't sure if I should mention it to you, either; but then I thought, you might need this more than anyone."

Catra flushed and fought down the urge to deny the truth of that. "You're probably right. Thank you," she added carefully. The two of them looked at each other, both of them struggling in their own ways to process that moment of vulnerability. Then Catra blinked and let herself slip into planning mode, where she felt much more comfortable. "You can probably tell Hordak. I assume he'll be helping you, and it's not like *he* is going to tell anyone. But I don't think anyone else. Not even Wrong Hordak. And make sure Emily doesn't spill to Scorpia."

Emily beeped indignantly, but Entrapta just laughed and twirled up onto her feet. "You've got it! Oooo, this is going to be so much fun!"

Catra followed her slowly up onto her feet, deliberately allowing herself to feel just slightly hopeful. Not a lot, but a bit. It was an impossible idea, but if anyone could do the impossible, it was Entrapta. "Let me know if you need anything. I can't do the science stuff, obviously, but anything else…"

"Like a liaison?" Entrapta said excitedly.

"Uh, sure?"

"AHA! Bright Moon log day twenty-three: I now have a lab partner *and* a liaison!"

Catra smiled to herself as she watched Entrapta swing off into the depths of the lab, already focused on her new project.

Two months after the end of the war

“Catra! I need to liaise!” Entrapta appeared suddenly in the doorway, distracting Catra right as Adora swept her leg low, sending Catra to the floor.

“Ha!” Adora crowed triumphantly.

“That doesn’t count, Entrapta distracted me!”

Adora smiled unrepentantly. “That sounds like a you problem.”

Catra growled playfully, preparing to retaliate, when Entrapta’s words sunk in. She craned her head around to look towards the doorway. “You need to… liaise?” She asked slowly, watching Entrapta’s face closely to make sure she hadn’t misunderstood.

Entrapta nodded urgently. “Yes! Whenever is convenient! But also, as soon as possible!”

Adora narrowed her eyes, looking between the two of them, and stuck out her hand to help Catra up. “Liaise?” She asked curiously.

“It’s just a little project I’m helping ‘Trapta with. Rain check on beating you?” Catra did her best to sound casual.

“Uh-huh, keep dreaming. Do you need my help too?” Adora asked, perking up.

“No! I mean,” Catra backtracked quickly as Adora’s face fell. “It’s nothing major. You already have so much on your plate right now.”

Adora grimaced. “Nothing *fun,* though.”

Catra laughed; she couldn’t help it. “What makes you think this would be fun?”

Adora smiled and tossed her arms loosely around Catra’s neck. “Because I’d be doing it with you, of course!”

Catra's heart did the funny *swoop* it always did when Adora said things like that. She gave in and leaned up to press a quick kiss on Adora's lips. "I'll tell you all about it later, alright?"

"Tell me about it now," Adora mumbled, pulling Catra in for another kiss.

"So are we going now, or…?" Entrapta's voice carried easily across the room.

Adora startled back, and Catra took the moment to slide out of her embrace, as much as she wanted to stay. "Yep, I'm coming." She jogged away quickly, pretending she couldn't hear Adora's grumbles from behind her. She turned at the doorway and blew a quick kiss back over her shoulder. "Later, I promise!" She called. Later, after she figured out what she could safely tell Adora. After she knew what Entrapta had discovered.

"So, what did you need to, uh, liaise about?" Catra asked as she jogged after Entrapta.

"Not here!" Entrapta called back.

Catra sighed and followed in silence the rest of the way back to Entrapta's lab, letting her mind wander back to sparring with Adora. her pleasant daydreaming shattered upon entering the lab, though, and her hand automatically rose to rub at the back of her neck. Hordak was standing at one of the tables, his back to the entrance. They had long since come to a stiff kind of understanding, put their own histories behind them as well as she could manage, but Hordak still looked like a Prime clone, and Catra… she still had to take a moment to remind herself that he was gone. Gone gone. Adora had healed the universe of him. She forced her hand back down to her side.

"Okay, I brought Catra!" Entrapta announced their entrance.

Hordak turned and gave a small nod. "Good." He looked at Catra. "I understand Entrapta has apprised you of the basics?"

Catra crossed her arms and leaned against one of the ubiquitous stacks of boxes. "Redo the reality-destroying portal now that it won't destroy reality, and pull Queen Angella out?"

"Very crudely put, but yes."

Entrapta practically vibrated with excitement. "Ohhh, it's so much more than that though!"

"I assume you don't want me for the science part, correct?" Catra cut in before Entrapta could start spiralling down one of her explanations.

"Right!" Entrapta said with a clap. "We have worked out what we *think* will work. The problem is, according to our models, *both* sides of the portal will open. It's like a door, right? And you can't just open a door one way. So what we need you to do is to make sure that Angella goes the right way!"

Catra frowned. "Make sure she comes through to Etheria, and not to, what, Despondos? Is that where the other side leads?"

"Yes! Probably! Hard to say, really! She might be able to tell us for sure, once she is back. She might be able to tell us *so much…*"

"How am I supposed to make sure she goes the right way?" Catra interrupted again.

Hordak answered while Entrapta was still lost in dreamy thought. "We believe that the surest way would be to create a critical mass of… attachments. A sort of gravitational pull of emotions."

"Gravi… You mean like get all of the people she loved, er, loves together? Sparkles and Micah and all?"

"Precisely!" Entrapta exclaimed, having dragged her attention back to the conversation at hand. "If we gather all the people who love her and that she loves in the area where the portal opens up, that should be enough to attract her in the right direction!"

Catra rubbed her head. “Really? That’s your plan? It just… doesn’t seem very scientific, is all.”

“On the contrary! There is *loads* of scientific evidence pointing to the power of emotional bonds!” Entrapta eagerly showed Catra a screen full of bar graphs. She had to take Entrapta’s word for it, that they showed scientific evidence to back up this hair-brained plan, because those graphs meant nothing to her. “And of course this isn’t just science, it’s also magic! And magic *definitely* has an emotional component.”

“Alright, so… where should we the portal open up?”

Chapter End Notes

Entrapta speaking in italics is so important to me personally anyway did she actually get permission from Glimmer to experiment on portals, or was Glimmer in the middle of five other things when Entrapta asked her?

"Are You Seriously Making Another Portal?"

Catra and Melog burst into Hordak's old lab — his former sanctum — at the same time that Adora materialized with Glimmer and Bow in the far corner, half hidden behind a broken vat. Melog looked over at them, but Catra only rushed forward towards Entrapta and Hordak. "Is it working?" She shouted over the roar of the portal.

"It's open, but the way we had to make it work means it's not stable! We only have a few minutes!" Entrapta yelled back.

"Where is she, then?"

"In essence we've only opened the door! She needs to come through!"

Adora stumbled forwards, vaguely aware of Bow and Glimmer on either side of her. "Catra, what are you doing?" She yelled.

Catra froze for a second then whirled around, eyes wild.

"Hi Adora! Too bad you don't still have your sword!" Entrapta waved happily.

"Are you seriously making another portal?" Glimmer screamed.

"Entrapta, we have all the new tech to make proper portals! What are you doing this for?" Bow stumbled towards Entrapta and Hordak, fighting against the wind from the portal.

Catra was still staring at Adora. "It's to get Angella back," she called.

Glimmer stumbled. "You're going to bring my mom back? *You can do that?*"

Catra finally looked away from Adora. "We're *trying.* I don't know if it'll work, that's why we didn't tell you! But we had a theory that

having you all here would create a kind of emotional resonance that would help attract her out—”

“It’s all theoretical, but thaumaturlogically sound! Hordak and I have recreated the original portal to the best of our abilities, but without the sword, of course. It’s open, but I’m not sure it’s stable enough for anyone to go through.” Entrapta looked nervously at the screens full of graphs and charts in front of her.

“Would the sword help?”

“Adora, *no.*” Catra stepped between Adora and Entrapta, her teeth bared.

Adora held her mismatched gaze. “Entrapta?”

“Yes, but it’s gone!”

Catra’s ears were pinned back. She had already figured it out, probably a while ago; Adora could see that in her face, in the frantic look in her eyes. This is why she hadn’t said anything to Adora about this plan. Adora gave her the ghost of a smile and summoned her sword.

“What do you mean, emotional resonance?” Bow asked.

“You are all beings of potent magical energy,” Hordak spoke up for the first time. “And you were all close with Angella emotionally. Theoretically, having you all grouped together nearby will act as a kind of magnet, a compass, that will pull her in this direction, from wherever she is currently between the dimensions.”

Glimmer’s eyes widened. “Can we make that pull stronger? How?”

The rest of the Alliance finally made it to the door of the lab, Scorpia in the lead. “What is going on?” Frosta yelled, as everyone started piling in.

“I need more room!” Entrapta yelled. “Catra, gather them in the hallway, and explain!”

Glimmer set her jaw and nodded. “Everyone out in the hallway, now!”

Catra looked between Adora and Glimmer, then hissed and followed the others out. Adora could hear her explaining what was going on and how they needed to help as they filed out into the hallway.

Adora walked the rest of the way to Entrapta. “Where do you need me?”

Entrapta looked at her and frowned in concern. “You’re the sword now, aren’t you? Yes, that makes sense, the First Ones only contained the energy of She-Ra. You’ll have to channel the portal if you do this. It will probably be painful. I can hold it without you, it’s—“

Adora put a hand on her shoulder. “It’s okay, I’ll do it. Where do you need me?”

Entrapta hesitated for a moment longer, her gaze flickering towards the door of the lab, then she nodded brusquely and pointed with one pigtail towards the portal frames. “The portal is trying to open there, in the frames, but the energy just won’t quite balance. The original sword was in the portal, of course, but maybe if you were just somewhere in the energy loop?”

Adora frowned at the setup. “The original portal centered on the sword. It was the key. You said you made this version as close as possible to the original, didn’t you?”

“Adora, you can’t.” Catra ran back into the lab. “I have them settled out in the hallway. They should be enough…”

“The portal isn’t stable enough to open,” Hordak said shortly. “We’re running out of time.”

Adora pulled Catra close and kissed her. “I’ll be okay, I promise. You’ve done your part, now let me do mine.”

Catra was tense in her arms. “If you die, I’ll haunt you forever.”

Adora laughed without much humor. “Deal.” Catra pulled her face in for one more kiss, then stepped back. Adora took a steadying breath, and then summoned She-Ra to the surface. She watched Catra narrow her eyes against the bright light, mouth grim.

As She-Ra, she could feel the pull of the portal much more clearly. It felt like it was trying to rip her into two copies of herself. She set her jaw and walked over to the center of the portal, keeping an eye on Entrapta and Hordak out the corner of her eye. They were watching whatever their screens were telling them, still trying to make it work without her. Maybe they could, but probably not.

The original portal needed a switch, because the sword was an inanimate key. Now she was both the key and the switch. She planted her feet, took one more deep breath, and opened the portal.

It *hurt.* It truly was like it was ripping her to pieces. On the other hand, it hurt less than when Light Hope had used her to channel the Heart of Etheria… for what that was worth. At first, all she could focus on was the pain; all of the rest of her senses were swept away. Gradually, though, she adjusted, and realized that she could hear — just a deafening roar of wind, but still — and smell — ozone, mostly — and, eventually, see. The room came into hazy focus: still Hordak’s old lab, although her view of it was now distorted and from a weirdly higher angle, like she was floating several feet off the ground. She saw Entrapta and Hordak huddled behind the main workstation, anchored by Entrapta’s hair. She saw Catra, her claws digging fiercely into the ground against the pull of the portal. And then beyond, in the hallway, the glowing presence of the princesses, more a sensation than sight. Another sensation, from somewhere beyond, reacting to the princesses. *Angella.*

Catra was looking at the portal somewhere beneath Adora’s vantage point, her face a mess of raw emotions. Adora saw her

mouth move, shouting something to Entrapta, but her words were obliterated before they reached Adora's… ears? Did she still have ears? Or a body? She felt a flash of panic, and the portal wavered in response. Entrapta and Hordak were looking nervously at the readings on their screens. Adora could tell that whatever energy source Entrapta had tapped to open the portal was running low, and soon She-Ra would be the only thing keeping it open. She could do it, she knew, but…

The portal wavered again and Adora put that thought to the side, focusing instead on the two glowing poles: the group of princesses and wizards in the world in front of her, and the lone spark behind her, drifting somewhere in the space between worlds. They were reacting like Entrapta had theorized, like calling to like, but the lone spark wasn't moving fast enough. Entrapta had started typing furiously at one of the keypads. And Catra's face had hardened into a look that made Adora's stomach swoop with anxiety. She said something to Entrapta that caused the princess to shake her head vigorously and type faster, neither of which made any dent in the resolve on Catra's face. *Don't…*

Catra lept into the portal.

It was a weird sensation. Adora could feel her in the maelstrom, a focused lump of fear and determination and anger and so much guilt. *Oh Catra.* The shockwave of emotions shook her control over the portal, and it took a particularly painful wrench to stabilize it.

She lost a few moments to the pain. When it cleared enough that she could see again, Glimmer had appeared in the lab. Her cloak was flapping wildly in the wind from the portal, almost like wings. She said something to Entrapta, who answered by pointing at the portal. Glimmer looked shocked, then her face slid into an expression so like Catra's had been just before she lept into the portal. Entrapta evidently saw it too, because one of her ponytails snapped out to wind around Glimmer's waist. *Thank you, Entrapta.* It was already hard enough with…

She sensed back into the portal. Catra was still there, her emotions shining a bright array of fear and desperation. The other point of light, the Angella one, was fainter, uncertain, now actively resisting the pull. Not good. Maybe Glimmer would help, if Adora thought she could handle her entering the portal without losing her grip. She would be more ready for it this time, sure, but it was getting harder to hold.

Not to hold it open, she realized, but to hold herself apart from it. The longer the portal was open, the less she felt herself distinct from it. The less she felt herself.

Focus on Catra. She wondered what the experience was like inside the portal. Was it like the first time, when the whole world changed? Or were they in some empty between space? She could feel Catra's desperation and anxiety growing, while Angella stayed the same remote sensation. Maybe Catra couldn't find her? Was there some way Adora could help? She could make the portal bigger… no, no, she shouldn't make the portal bigger, that wouldn't help anyone. Where had that thought come from? An effect of the pain, probably. Just need to keep holding it steady while… while… What was she doing?

Catra's fear spiked, jerking Adora back into her mind with a rush of panic. *Focus, keep it together,* she told herself fiercely. *For Catra.* The lab wavered briefly back into focus, which is how Adora realized that it had gone out of focus. Micah had joined Glimmer standing by Entrapta, and the rest of the Alliance was hovering behind Bow by the doorway. They were worried. Or was it Angella who was worried? Maybe everyone was worried. Was she worried? No, she had Catra. If anyone could do this, it was Catra. Whatever this was.

Two heavy paws landed on her shoulders, spectral claws pricking through to her skin — which is how she realized she still had both shoulders and skin. Melog's head thrust into her line of sight. Their eyes bore into her. Eyes so blue. She-Ra blue, Catra had said once. Were they trying to communicate something? Only Catra could understand them… *Catra. Still in the portal.* Catra's

emotions had swung back to pure determination. That was probably good. *Is that good, Melog?*

Then Catra's emotions were suddenly gone.

The Portal, Revisited

She had expected it to be loud inside the portal, roaring like it had been on the other side. Landing — landing? — on the other side felt like being abruptly shut off from a thunderstorm, the flick of a switch, her ears stuffed with cotton. It was pitch dark, and whatever she was standing on didn't feel real against her toes.

On some level, she had been expecting it to be like — to be a copy of the real world, but with whatever twists Angella's mind made with it. Like the first time. But Entrapta had said that Queen Angella had been trapped *between* dimensions. There was nothing here to copy, because there was nothing at all. Which meant… why did they think Queen Angella would still be here, waiting? And even if she was, would she still be herself anymore? Could she be?

Catra had a sudden, vivid flashback to: climbing. Her hands were in front of her face, clawing at unreal cliffs. Her right hand was *wrong.*

She had fallen into nothingness before, and climbed back out changed.

She stuffed that memory back down, something to address at another time. Preferably one in which she was standing on a solid and real ground, with a solid and real world around her, and a solid and real Adora who wasn't being forced to once again be a hero for everyone…

That last thought shook her into action. This might have been between dimensions, but Catra was definitely still real (she patted herself to check), and she was pretty sure she was standing on *something,* as dubious as it might have felt. She set her jaw and took a step. The ground held under her foot. It was smooth, and slightly squishy in a way that she didn't like to think about. She took another step forward. There was nothing to go towards or away from, no way to orient herself, so one foot in front of the

other one was as good a choice as any. She had done that often enough in the past anyway.

Ten steps later, something changed. It was subtle, but in the nothingness, anything stood out — even the minuscule change from blank nothing to watching nothing. She froze with one foot in the air.

The watching blinked.

She set her foot down, and the nothing tore.

She was falling, wind tearing at her eyes, her ears, her clothes. It was too bright to see. If there was ground under her, she had no way to stop herself from an inevitable intimate greeting. If there wasn't ground under her… She stole a breath from the wind and screamed the only thing she could think of.

"Angella!"

She landed. It *hurt.* But that meant she was still alive to hurt, which was more than she had expected.

Something moved behind her, and she forced air back in her lungs, trying to get her body to respond. The overwhelming light dimmed the tiniest bit, and she managed to crack her eyelids a sliver apart. Blinding white stabbed her eyes, and the air she'd managed to inhale whooshed out of her again in a pained groan.

"You," said a voice thick with disdain. "I didn't invite you here."

Catra grit her teeth against the pain. She was getting out of practice, working through pain; she had welcomed getting out of practice. "Queen Angella," she started, trying to arrange her limbs under her to stand — or maybe on second thought to just sit up.

"Queen, is it? What manners. I didn't know the Horde had it in them."

Catra managed to lever herself halfway up and counted that a victory. “I’m not with the Horde anymore. There is no Horde anymore.”

“Branched off on your own, then? You made a mistake coming here.”

“What? No—“

“I may be trapped here, but this is now the seat of my power, a world to bend to my will.” Angella’s voice had lost the disdain, and gained nothing in its place, her words cold and empty. Cold, empty, and far too much like… Catra’s eyes flew open in spite of the glare, and landed on the figure looming over her: not the willowy, winged figure that she had caught distant glimpses of in the past, but a different, all too familiar figure.

"Little Sister, it has been far too long." Horde Prime blinked his poison green eyes in swift succession and smiled down at her.

The physical pain Catra was feeling fled before panic and terror. “No, you’re dead; Adora—" Her throat closed over the rest of that sentence, and Horde Prime laughed into the silence.

“Oh, my child, you know that I would never truly leave you. I will always be here, in the dark corners of your mind, waiting for you to stumble.” Catra closed her eyes tightly, as if that could block out the words, could block out the presence. Instead, the voice started to change again. “And stumble you will, you worthless waste of space.” She opened her eyes again, and stared up at the blank mask of Shadow Weaver, no longer shattered on some ancient cavern floor, but once again whole and affixed to the face of its owner. The gem in its forehead shone a bright, wrathful red. “You will stumble, and bring everyone down with you. Bring *Adora* down with you.”

The figure of Shadow Weaver folded and suddenly Catra found herself face to face with herself, the portal-eaten version of herself, which crouched and studied her with mismatched eyes:

no longer amber and blue, but fire and void. The Portal-Catra reached out her unreal right hand and, worse than any violence, gently ran those empty fingers down Catra's jaw to her chin, tipping her face up. "And that's always been the problem, hasn't it. We don't bring anything good into the world, we tear everything down. Those Princesses out there right now are only tolerating your presence because you're tying yourself into knots, keeping your claws sheathed. Keeping your true nature in check. The second you step a hair out of line, the second you reach out, the second you start dragging them down, they will drop you. And then Adora will see you for who you really are. How long do you think you can put the inevitable off? How long before your true nature shows itself, and —" the Portal-Catra's only warning was a slight narrowing of her eyes before her claws shot out and bit deeply into Catra's face. "You remember what you really are."

"Well, I think I've seen enough," said a new voice from somewhere behind Catra. The Portal-Catra froze, glitched, faded into an insubstantial outline, claws releasing from Catra's cheeks. Her head dropped heavily before she regained the motor control to lift it on her own and then swivel around to face the newcomer.

Queen Angella stood, wings folded, hands folded, a thoughtful frown on her face as she looked past Catra at, she assumed, the Portal-Catra. "The only things in this place are those which you bring with you," she said, half to herself. Her eyes drifted down to the real Catra, and her mouth made a little jerk of sympathy. "But memories can hurt worst of all, can't they?" She bent at the waist, close enough that Catra could feel the slight breeze from her hair moving, and held out a cloth.

The light was no longer aggressively glaring, Catra noticed, now only a uniform white glow. She looked at the proffered cloth in confusion. "You're bleeding," Angella clarified.

Catra reached out, half expecting her hand to simply go through the cloth. It didn't. She brought it to her face, wincing at the sting. "Are you… real?" She asked hoarsely, then winced at the stupidity of that question. As if the answer would mean anything.

Angella smiled ruefully. “I’m not a figment of your imagination, no.” Then she looked around at the surrounding blank whiteness. “Though I am not sure I can say definitively that I am real, or that anything else here is.” She lapsed into silence, her face vague and thoughtful.

Catra checked the cloth, which was becoming steadily redder. “Real enough to hurt, apparently.”

Angella’s focus swung back to Catra. “How did you come to be here?”

“Entrapta reconstructed the portal, this time with a working off switch. I came to get you out.”

“I thought I felt a change… I had been… sleeping…” Her voice sharpened. “Why do you think I would come with you? What purpose does the Horde have for me?” Angella drew back slightly, and her brows pinched together in the same way that Glimmer’s did when reconstruction negotiations were going particularly poorly. Catra almost found herself laughing at that, slightly hysterically.
“There is no Horde anymore. We’re, Entrapta and I, we’re with the Princesses now. We… Glimmer wanted to come, but we wouldn’t let her. Being the queen and all. I’m… more expendable.”

Angella’s frown shifted slightly. Catra tried to track the change, but couldn’t quite interpret it. She took a breath — her lungs were feeling strangely shallow — and continued. “We’re rebuilding Etheria. All of the Princesses. And… King Micah.”

Angella froze for a long moment. Then she sagged, like her strings had been cut. “Now I know you aren’t real.” She started to turn away.

Catra scrambled up desperately. Her limbs weren’t responding quite right, but she ignored that. “Wait! I promise you I’m real. I…” She stopped to cough. “I don’t know what to say to convince you of that. Except, even if I’m not, what do you have to lose?”

Angella stayed half turned away, her gaze fixed somewhere in the distance, as if there was something, anything, to see.

“Please,” Catra added.

In the light the moon sends back

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra hadn't given any thought on how to actually exit the portal, but that turned out to not be a problem. As soon as Angella's face firmed up into an expression of determination, deciding to trust Catra, a whirling spiral opened next to them and practically sucked them through — and out.

They landed in the lab to a chaos of sound and movement. Catra's knees buckled under her, and out of the corner of her eye she saw Angella collapse as well. There were figures rushing around in the cacophony. Gradually, Catra's ears kicked into gear enough to start sorting out voices, even if her eyes were still recovering.

"… Mom!"

"… close it now!…"

"Angie!"

"I can't, Adora's still holding it open…!" Entrapta's voice cut through the fog to Catra's brain. She whirled around, vaguely aware of hands on her shoulders, and forced her eyes to focus on the scene.

Adora was in the eye of the portal, suspended in the air. Catra's memory flashed back to retrieving the Failsafe. "Adora!" She screamed, her voice torn away by the wind. Her eyes still weren't quite cooperating, but it looked like there was some distortion in front of Adora. She blinked her eyes viciously. The distortion stayed put, its outline sharpening slightly into the shape of… "Melog! Get her out of there!"

Adora had felt her heart stop — which is how she knew she still had a heart — when Catra's emotions disappeared, and for a moment the pain of the portal faded entirely in her panic. Then she saw motion beyond Melog, in the lab: Catra was there, out of the portal, her arm around a tall figure. More figures were rushing towards them. Wafts of emotion reached her: joy, shock, more joy. Some leftover undercurrents of anxiety and fear. Catra had done it.

Adora sighed and started to let go. Melog dug their claws in sharply. Why? She was done. She had done her part. Now she could let go, sink into the oblivion waiting behind her. Melog gripped her harder, but she looked past them at the lab. The figures were back to huddling away from the might of her portal, except one. *Catra.* Why was she looking like that? They had succeeded. She watched Catra's lips move. She was shouting something. She was… were those tears? Was she crying? Oh stars, why was she crying?

Melog yelled in her face, and Adora's thoughts came rushing back with crystal clarity. Shit, she was still holding the portal open. She had tried to let go in the wrong direction. She needed to close the portal, not close herself to the world. And Melog was trying to guide her, to pull her in the right direction. She reached up — look, arms! — and hugged their neck, and shut off the flow of magic to the portal. For a moment it roared on before dissipating like mist in the daylight. She and Melog hung suspended several feet off the ground for a moment longer.

"Adora!" Catra practically pulled them out of the air with her embrace. Adora freed her arms from around Melog to return the hug, reveling in the solid warmth of Catra as she returned to her normal *Adora* form. "*Never* do that again, you idiot."

"That I think I can safely promise." She pulled back slightly, and caught sight of Catra's face. "You're bleeding!"

Catra winced and brought a hand up to her face. "Ouch. Yeah. Ran into some painful memories…" She trailed off as Adora

immediately started healing her. “You don’t… it’s not that bad… you’re tired…”

“Shut up,” Adora said. She frowned as her magic started working through Catra’s various injuries. “Tell me what happened later.” Then she finally looked over Catra’s shoulder at the scene in the lab.

Queen — was she still queen now? — Angella was nearly hidden in a sea of activity. Glimmer and Micah crying and hugging her, Bow and the Princesses chattering excitedly, Entrapta trying to get data… Angella’s eyes snagged on Adora’s from over the crowd of heads.

Adora shoved her way towards her in response. She caught her right as Angella started to collapse.

“Mom!” “Angie!” Glimmer and Micah yelled in unison.

Angella smiled as Adora started trying to figure out how to heal her. “I’m fine, I’m fine, just a little weak.”

“That long between dimensions, it would make sense for there to be some adverse physical effects,” Entrapta said helpfully.

“How long…?”

“About two years,” Glimmer said.

“Much less time than I spent on Beast Island,” Micah added. Angella looked at him. He reached forward for her hand, and placed on the side of his own face. “Real,” he said, and she burst into tears.

It was a long time before things started to calm down. Scorpia quickly and readily announced that they should delay rebuilding the Fright Zone, but Angella, who was getting updates on what she had missed from three different sides, equally quickly said

that that was hardly necessary. Glimmer then tried to offer her the crown back, but Angella firmly turned this down. “Absolutely not. From what I have already heard alone, you’re doing a far better job than I ever did.” Which started both of them and Micah crying again.

It was deep into the night when Adora finally got a chance to speak with Angella relatively alone. Catra was standing nearby — she hadn’t let Adora get much farther than arm’s length away since the portal closed — but otherwise it was just the two of them for a moment. “Queen Angella…” Adora started hesitantly.

“Just Angella now,” Angella said comfortably.

“Right. Sorry. Going to take some getting used to that,” Adora chuckled nervously and ignored the half-glance that Catra threw her way. “It’s just… I want to… When I was healing you, I noticed…” She pinched her lips together tightly for a moment, then finished in a rush. “I don’t think you’re immortal anymore.”

Angella stared at her for a moment, then threw back her head and laughed. Adora blinked in astonishment. “Sorry,” Angella said as she recovered herself. “It’s not funny, I know but… oh, it is such a relief.”

“It… is?”

Angella smiled gently, and for a dizzying moment Adora had a flash of what it might be like to have a mother smile at her. “Oh yes. You’re still too young to understand — and cherish that youth! — but I have faced the prospect of first staring down the empty years of my life spinning on and on, and then staring down an eternity between dimensions; and, Adora, the thought of an end sounds like the greatest gift.” She placed her hand on Adora’s shoulder. “Thank you.” Then she looked up, somewhere just past Adora. “And thank you as well, Catra.”

Adora followed her gaze towards Catra, who was blushing awkwardly. “It was nothing—“ Catra started, only to be cut off by

the sweep of one of Angella’s wings, pulling her in, and then Angella was hugging both of them in the shelter of her wings.

“Thank you.”

Chapter title from "Little Sleep's-Head Sprouting Hair in the Moonlight" by Galway Kinnell

Chapter End Notes

> Well uh those ghost stories sure got away from me a little bit there, didn't they…

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